

Week 6: Character in Biblical Narrative

How to Read the Bible — 19-Week Study

Biblical authors reveal character in their own particular way — tonight we'll look at how, and what it trains us to notice.

1. Think of a character from a movie or show you love who isn't simply "good" or "bad" — someone morally complicated, hard to pin down. What keeps you interested in them?
2. **Read 1 Samuel 9:1-2.** What details does the text give us about Saul when he's introduced — his family background, his appearance? Why do you think the narrator chose to tell us this detail about him instead of simply saying he'd make a good king or a bad one?
3. **Read Genesis 12:10-20.** What does Abraham ask Sarah to tell the Egyptians, and why does he ask her to do it? The narrator never says whether this was right or wrong — he just tells us what happened and what it led to. What does it do to you as a reader when the Bible refuses to hand you a verdict on a character like this?
4. **Read Genesis 32:28.** What new name is Jacob given here, and what reason does the text give for it? Names carry a lot of weight in biblical narrative — they're small brushstrokes with big implications. What does it tell you that God renames a lifelong deceiver "one who struggles with God," rather than something like "one who has arrived"?
5. **Read Daniel 6.** What do Daniel's enemies admit they can't find against him, and what's the one thing they're able to use? How does a character like Daniel function differently in a story than someone like Abraham or Jacob?
6. Biblical characters are almost always a mixed bag — capable of real faith and real failure, sometimes in the very same chapter. Why do you think the biblical authors were so committed to portraying people this way instead of giving us clear heroes and villains?

7. God is the one character who shows up on the very first page of the Bible and is still present on the last page. What difference does it make that the Bible's real "main character," in that sense, isn't any human being but God himself?
8. Which biblical character's flaws or failures do you find yourself most relating to right now, and why?
9. Given everything we've talked about tonight, how might you read Bible stories differently this week — paying more attention to what's shown through a character's choices than what's simply told to you about them?